

location, areas of interest, languages known and prior volunteering experience.

Networking Citizens

The Mumbai floods swung the Karmayog team into action like never before. From getting donors who sponsored lakhs of rupees worth of medicines, to others who could bodily help victims, to allocating funds, Karmayog became an information interface. All the team members were available for contact 24/7.

Somani refers to a PIL (public interest litigation) filed by a citizen in the court over the bad condition of roads in Mumbai. The court retaliated by asking for solid evidence on the same. Ever since, Karmayog has been bombarded with mails from several infuriated citizens—with actual pictures of potholed Mumbai city roads in a state of utter neglect!

Somani also cites another example: the stray dog menace. On the one hand, Karmayog received passionate letters from animal lovers, and on the other, those who had been bitten by canines poured out their woes on the site!

“Being an online medium, Karmayog can enable cross-fertilisation of ideas—there is a sharing of views—and thus people can find a balanced approach to their problems and live harmoniously. By and large, the judiciary gives inflexible solutions to problems, the government cannot help everyone, and its policies are lopsided; in such a scenario, citizens will have to help themselves.

NGOs do not want to preach to the converted—those who are already helping with charitable causes—it is essential to leverage those who are sympathetic to the cause but have hitherto been unable to help,” says Somani.

Networking With NGOs

In terms of information, resources and activities, Karmayog.com has all a donor or volunteer would ever require.

To get a better idea, consider this: under the ‘Issues/Causes’ link, there are 40-odd other links dealing with issues as diverse as AIDS and drug abuse. Under one of the links titled ‘Disabilities—Hearing’, there’s information on the hearing and speech-challenged sector. There’s a list of hearing aid makers in India, links

to useful Web sites, libraries of articles, Acts, laws, Government schemes, and an e-group.

And under ‘Mumbai’ alone are listed 24 schools for the hearing challenged (with ratings), 18 other NPOs (with ratings), 95 ENT Hospitals, surgeons, doctors and clinics (with the respective consulting fees), 50 hearing aid clinics and suppliers (with ratings), and profiles of hearing-challenged individuals and training institutes.

As you can imagine, such a compilation is of immense help. For instance, parents of a hearing-impaired child searching for a suitable school would be easily able to locate an NGO that meets their criteria through the listings on Karmayog.com.

Channelising Resources

“NGOs are doing fantastic work, and even a little support can multiply their effectiveness. But NGOs need to find people who can help and people also need to know how to support them. Due to lack of information and co-ordination between NGOs, there is often duplication of work, inadequate and fragmented knowledge.

“It is here that, as a readily accessible online resource, Karmayog.com acts as a facilitator between NGOs and people,” says Somani. Karmayog also independently evaluates and recommends NGOs. Since January 2005, it started the ‘Non-profit-of-the-month’ idea, wherein it carefully profiles and recommends one deserving NGO every month, in most cases, a low-budget one.

Here, in addition to the general details about the NGO on the site, the Karmayog team personally visits the NGO and notes the administration, upkeep and facilities, and then gives the rating. This, in turn, helps donors directly help NGOs—as donors need to be assured that their contribution will reach the actual beneficiaries.

You Can Reach Out!

You may feel strongly about civic issues and you may also have the empathy to do good, but not always have the means to reach out. With Karmayog.com, you need not be a mute spectator any longer: you can play an active role to make our world, clichéd as it may seem, a better place to live in. ☑

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